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Scapegoat or manipulated victim? Metaphorical representations of the Sino-US currency dispute in Chinese and American financial news

Abstract: This article compares the metaphorical representations of the currency dispute between China and the United States in two newspapers, i.e., *China Daily* (CD) from China and *The New York Times* (NYT) from the United States, in order to investigate the role of conceptual metaphors in framing the dispute and constructing the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper. The findings suggest that while five dominant metaphor themes can be identified in both newspapers: PHYSICAL MOVEMENT, PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR, HEALTH/STRENGTH, VICTIM, and MACHINE, they are appropriated and reformulated in different ways to construct the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper. NYT prefers to frame the dispute as a physical conflict and the Renminbi as a victim of government control and manipulation and argues for the overhaul of the machine of China's exchange rate policies. CD favors the conceptualization of the dispute as a war and the Renminbi as a scapegoat for the problems of the United States and insists on the adjustment of the machine of China's exchange rate policies.

Keywords: metaphor, currency dispute, exchange rate, critical metaphor analysis, financial news

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1 Introduction

As one of the main issues to arise between China and the United States in the last decade, the currency dispute over the exchange rate of the Renminbi (i.e., the Chinese yuan) has drawn wide international interest and received extensive media coverage in both China and the United States. It has been demonstrated

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that media play an indispensible role in bringing home to the public issues of international significance and shaping their opinions (Fairclough 1995). This article compares the representations of the issue in two newspapers, namely *China Daily* (CD) from China and *The New York Times* (NYT) from the United States, through a critical examination of the metaphorical representations of the currency dispute in their news reports. The primary purpose is to explore the role of conceptual metaphors in framing this issue and constructing the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper.

Since the introduction of conceptual metaphor theory (CMT) by Lakoff and Johnson (1980), metaphor has been understood as a matter of both language and thought. This has given rise to a wealth of studies on the existence and functions of conceptual metaphors in different types of discourses, ranging from those related to a particular event to those from different registers, genres, cultures, and languages (e.g., Dudley-Evans and Henderson 1990; Henderson 1994; Dirven et al. 2003; Deignan and Potter 2004; Semino 2008). While traditional studies in cognitive linguistics focused on the identification and analysis of semantic features of conceptual metaphors, recent studies have turned their attention to the rhetorical and ideological significance of metaphors in specific contexts (Koller 2005; López and Llopis 2010; Charteris-Black 2004; Lakoff 2004). Especially in the analysis of public and political discourses, numerous examples of conceptual metaphors that serve to construct competing ideologies in the representations of a certain issue have already been pointed out (e.g., Chiang and Duann 2007; Flowerdew and Leong 2007; Burnes 2011). In view of the growing significance of business discourse in our lives, some researchers have also turned to financial news to investigate the role of conceptual metaphors in the construction of different representations and evaluations of a certain issue or reality (e.g., Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003; Vaghi and Venuti 2004; Semino 2002; Herrera-Soler and White 2012).

The currency dispute between China and the United States serves as a good case for study in view of its contentious nature and the constant negotiations and struggles involved during the process. CD and NYT are selected for comparison in this study. As the largest and most influential national English newspaper, CD represents a typical party organ and serves as a main channel for China's external communication (Guo and Huang 2002). NYT is regarded as a typical example of Anglo-American newspapers and often taken as a newspaper of choice for the study of news reporting in the United States (e.g., Li 2009; Amer 2009). It is thus of great interest to investigate how conceptual metaphors are used in the two newspapers to frame the issue and construct their argumentative positions and ideological stances with respect to the dominant national interests in each country. In the following part, I first give a brief introduction to the

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background of the issue and previous studies on metaphors in financial news. Section 3 sketches the main points of a critical approach to metaphor studies, i.e., critical metaphor analysis. Section 4 introduces the data and specifies the analytic procedure. Section 5 presents the main findings, followed by a brief conclusion in Section 6.

2 Research background

2.1 Contextualization of this study

Although the history of the currency dispute can be traced back to January of 1994 when China first adopted the floating exchange rate policy and pegged the yuan to the US dollar, it did not emerge as a key issue between China and the United States until the turn of the new millennium as a result of the slump in the world economy. The intense nature of this issue can be perceived in the three rounds of pressure from the United States in the last decade, occurring between 2002 and 2003, 2005 and 2006, and 2009 and 2010, respectively (Lu 2011). The mounting international pressure, especially the pressure from the US government, contributed to the exchange rate reform on 21 July 2005 by the Chinese government, which led to a 2.1% rise in the exchange rate of the Renminbi to the dollar and allowed the exchange rate of the Renminbi to be determined more flexibly with reference to a basket of currencies (Zhou 2009: 1). The following several years saw the gradual appreciation of the Renminbi. However, the ensuing global economic crisis in 2008 and the side-effects of the Renminbi appreciation on its economy made the Chinese government refuse to let the Renminbi further appreciate, choosing instead to let it fluctuate on that rate, to the increasing dissatisfaction of the US government. In order to press China to let the Renminbi appreciate, the US Congress even passed the *Currency Reform for Fair Trade Act* on 24 September 2010. However, the dispute is still going on and shows no sign of cooling down.

As can be seen from its development, the currency dispute is characterized by constant struggles and negotiations. For China, it has to show its positive stance toward the improvement of its exchange rate policies in order to enter the international arena and maintain its role as a global factory. However, China has continually insisted on setting the pace of appreciation according to its own will in view of the actual and potential consequences of Renminbi appreciation on the Chinese economy. The United States, for its part, has made continuous efforts to press China for further appreciation of the Renminbi on the grounds

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that China has gained an unfair advantage through its exchange rate policies. Despite its constant requests for Renminbi appreciation, the US government has so far refrained from taking aggressive measures against China. This also results in discordant voices inside the United States as regards whether and how to punish China for its exchange rate policies. It contributes to the delicate nature of the issue, which, after all the fuss, turns out to be, more often than not, a verbal war rather than a life-or-death conflict.

2.2 Metaphors in financial news

As an influential specialized type of discourse, financial news has been subject to extensive scrutiny for metaphor study in the last decade (White 2003). This can be attributed to several factors. First, it has been repeatedly emphasized in CMT that one of the important functions of conceptual metaphors is to talk about unfamiliar and abstract areas of experience in terms of familiar and concrete areas of experience (Lakoff and Johnson 1980; Semino 2008). Since financial news concerns economic issues, it has to turn to the frequent use of conceptual metaphors to conceptualize abstract concepts in economics (Henderson 2000; Charteris-Black 2000). This is coupled with the special need to enhance news reports' reader appeal, which also requires financial news to employ conceptual metaphors, because most news readers are non-experts with no specialized knowledge of economics (Koller 2003). Besides, the current difficult financial situation in many countries also brings home to the public the importance of financial news in their daily lives, so financial issues have turned into "a burning topic of international interest" (López and Llopis 2010: 3301).

Traditional studies on metaphors in financial news used to approach it as a sample of economic discourse, so these metaphors identified are often taken as characterizing the language of economics and finance *per se* (e.g., White 2003; Charteris-Black 2000; Charteris-Black and Ennis 2001). Some recent studies on metaphor use in financial news do address the semantic dimension as well as the rhetorical and ideological dimensions of conceptual metaphors (e.g., Semino 2002; Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003; Charteris-Black 2004: Ch. 7; Koller 2005; Vaghi and Venuti 2004; Semino 2008; López and Llopis 2010). For example, in a study on the metaphorical representation of the euro in British and Italian newspapers, Semino (2002) found that despite a great deal of similarity in the use of the most frequent metaphorical patterns, such as BIRTH, JOURNEYS, and CONTAINERS, they are exploited and extended in English and Italian newspapers to highlight different concerns about the monetary union in the two countries.

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Charteris-Black and Musolff (2003) compared the metaphorical construction of euro trading in British and German financial press in a period of turbulent financial trading. The findings suggest that although financial press in both countries describes euro trading in terms of up/down movement and health, English reports also characterize the euro as an active agent with COMBAT metaphors, while German reports depict it as a beneficiary of institutional actions. These studies suggest the importance of contextualized metaphor analysis, and address the cognitive, linguistic, and rhetorical dimensions of metaphors simultaneously. Following this trend, this article analyzes the metaphorical construction of the currency dispute in CD and NYT, but unlike the above studies, it is concerned with the role of metaphors in the construction of the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper. The basic argument is that it is the incorporation, appropriation, and manipulation of these metaphor themes and metaphorical expressions that are crucial to the construction of the argumentative position and ideological stance of a particular newspaper (cf. Zinken 2007).

3 Critical metaphor analysis

The analysis of this research is based mainly on the approach of critical metaphor analysis (CMA) proposed by Charteris-Black (2004). CMA is characterized by an integration of the insights from cognitive linguistics, critical discourse analysis (CDA), pragmatics, and corpus linguistics. Unlike traditional cognitive semantic analysis, CMA draws attention to the pragmatic and rhetorical functions of metaphor use in language, based on the understanding that metaphor is also a result of the speaker/writer's choice in specific contexts. Charteris-Black (2004: 1) argues that "metaphor is a prime example of how pragmatics – context-specific linguistic choices by speakers – impinge on semantics – the linguistic system for the realization of meaning," so an understanding of metaphor in language use should take into account the interdependence of its semantic, pragmatic, and cognitive dimensions. It is semantic because it involves the "stretching of linguistic system to accommodate change in the conceptual system," and it is pragmatic in that "it can also serve as a stylistic resource for conveying authorial evaluation" (Charteris-Black 2004: 8).

CMA argues that metaphor should be a central component of critical discourse analysis (CDA), because the analysis of metaphor use in specific contexts can reveal not only the beliefs, attitudes, and feelings of text producers but also the underlying ideologies. Koller (2005) argues that critical and cognitive

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approaches can be combined, because they share certain common grounds and can gain from each other. Hart (2008) further points out that cognitive linguistics can contribute to CDA by helping to explain the "pervasiveness" and "persuasiveness" of metaphors. However, as Chilton (2005) has observed, metaphor remains the "missing link" of mainstream CDA, and Wodak (2006) also acknowledges that cognitive approaches have been rejected and excluded from CDA for unjustified reasons. CMA argues for a critical analysis of metaphor. It suggests that the pragmatic dimension should be analyzed in terms of its ideological and rhetorical significances. The last few years have witnessed a growing number of studies oriented toward this direction (e.g., Chilton 1996; Zinken 2003; Charteris-Black 2004; Koller 2005; Chiang and Duann 2007; Flowerdew and Leong 2007).

Apart from the above theoretical claims, CMA is also noted for its corpus-based methodology. Crucial to this methodology are a comparative perspective and an emphasis on actual language uses. The availability of large corpora provides attested linguistic evidences for metaphor analysis, resulting in a departure from traditional reliance on intuition. Besides, a comparative perspective makes it possible to identify metaphors that characterize a particular domain of discourse. Since the primary concern of this article is the role of metaphor in the construction of the argumentative position and ideological stance of a particular newspaper, two comparable specialized corpora are compiled to expose the similarities and discrepancies in the metaphorical construction of the currency dispute by newspapers from opposing sides of the dispute.

4 Data and analytic methods

The present analysis is based on two corpora (i.e., CD and NYT) which respectively collect all the financial news reports (excluding commentaries and letters-to-the-editor) in the two newspapers concerning the currency dispute from 2001 to 2011. The CD corpus consists of 228 news reports (133603 tokens), and the NYT corpus includes 271 news reports (238157 tokens). The two corpora are comparable, because all of the collected news reports are closely related to the currency dispute.

Considering the primary purpose of this article, I confine the analysis of metaphors to the analysis of the clauses including the three key terms which are used interchangeably to refer to the Renminbi (i.e., *yuan*, *Renminbi*, and *currency*) rather than the analysis of the whole corpora. It is based on the belief that these clauses referring to the Renminbi are at the core of the representations of the currency dispute and most revealing as regards how the currency dispute is metaphorically constructed in the two newspapers (cf. Chiang and Duann 2007;

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Table 1: Frequencies of the three terms in CD and NYT.

Types	CD		NYT	
	Freq.	Norm.	Freq.	Norm.
Yuan	1,337	10,007	604	2,536
Renminbi	338	2,530	495	2,078
Currency	753	5,636	1,649	6,924
Total	2,428	1,8173	2,748	11,539

López and Llopis 2010). The primary concerns are not the existence and intensity of metaphors in a particular corpus (cf. De Landtsheer and Koch 2005) but rather what metaphors are used in a particular newspaper when referring to the Renminbi and how they contribute to the construction of the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper. The corpus-analytic tool Wordsmith 5.0 is employed for the extraction of the concordance citations of the three key terms (Deignan 2005). While a concordance line is sufficient for the identification of metaphorical expressions in a clause in most cases, the larger co-text of a certain key term may also be referenced to determine whether some expressions are metaphorical or not in a few cases. Table 1 shows the actual and normalized (per million) frequencies of the three key terms in each newspaper.

As Table 1 shows, the two newspapers have different preferences for the three terms. For the convenience of analysis and comparison, a total of 1000 concordance lines from each newspaper are randomly sampled for analysis, with 400 for both *yuan* and *currency* and 200 for *Renminbi*.

The present analysis relies on a combination of the three-stage analytic framework proposed by Charteris-Black (2004) and the metaphor identification procedure (MIP) proposed by the Pragglejaz Group (Pragglejaz Group 2007; Semino 2008). Charteris-Black (2004) proposes to analyze metaphors in discourse in terms of three stages: identification, interpretation, and explanation. Metaphor identification involves the identification of those expressions which are metaphorical, but the identification of a metaphor in natural discourse is not without problems (Cameron and Low 1999; Low et al. 2010), so the MIP proposed by the Pragglejaz Group is also borrowed for the identification of metaphorical expressions related to the currency dispute (Pragglejaz Group 2007; Semino 2008). Based on the MIP, all the expressions whose contextual meanings deviate from their basic meanings are identified as metaphorical (Steen et al. 2010). In terms of quantification, all metaphorically used words occurring in close proximity to each other in a clause and related to the same source domain are characterized as *one* instance of metaphorical expression (Semino 2002).

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Metaphor interpretation involves the interpretation of each of these metaphorical expressions in terms of their underlying cognitive models as well as their pragmatic significances (Charteris-Black 2004: 37–38). Each metaphor is first interpreted in terms of their underlying cognitive models and quantified. Meanwhile, particular attention is paid to the implicit and explicit evaluative meanings they may carry in specific contexts. Metaphor explanation concerns the explanation of metaphors in terms of their rhetorical functions and the ideologies behind their use. All of the metaphors identified are explained in terms of their underlying ideologies, and their roles in the construction of the ideological stance of each newspaper.

In order to guarantee the accuracy of the analysis, keyword analysis is also performed when necessary by comparing the use of certain metaphorical expressions in a subject corpus with their use in a general reference corpus, the 5 million sampler corpus of the British National Corpus (BNC) (Semino 2008). Therefore, the present analyses are both qualitative and quantitative. Qualitative analyses concern the identification of each metaphorical expression and the determination of their evaluative meanings in each clause, while quantitative analyses focus on the quantification of each metaphor theme and the comparison of their distribution in the two newspapers.

5 Findings

A close examination of the 1000 concordance citations of each newspaper reveals that the metaphorical expressions in the two newspapers come largely from five source domains: physical movement, machine, health/strength, physical conflict/war, and victim. They are used respectively to conceptualize the five relevant target domains of the currency dispute: exchange rate change, exchange rate policies, the state of the Renminbi's value, currency dispute, and the Renminbi itself. Examples are as follows:

Type 1: EXCHANGE RATE CHANGE IS PHYSICAL MOVEMENT:

(1) (CD, 29/06/2010)
... believes that China's *currency* will **rise** by a large margin and ...

Type 2: THE STATE OF THE RENMINBI'S VALUE IS A STATE OF HEALTH/STRENGTH:

(2) (NYT, 14/04/2010)
Zhou Xiaochuan ... also seemed to lend support to the idea of a **stronger** *currency* ...

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Type 3: EXCHANGE RATE POLICIES ARE A MACHINE:

(3) (CD, 16/01/2008)
China **depegged** its *currency* from the greenback in July 2005 ...

Type 4: THE CURRENCY DISPUTE IS A PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR:

(4) (NYT, 20/10/2010)
... critics accuse the United States and other rich nations of **waging** an international *currency* **war** that harks to the protectionist ...

Type 5: THE RENMINBI IS A VICTIM:

(5) (NYT, 01/04/2010)
... that it would not be named a *currency* **manipulator** either on ...

The result does not show much deviance from the findings of previous studies on metaphors in economic discourse or financial news. It has been demonstrated that economic discourse and financial news feature the frequent use of mechanical, biological, physical movement, and physical conflict/war metaphors (e.g., Charteris-Black 2004: Ch. 7; Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003; White 2003; Koller 2003). The prevalence of these metaphors in the present data is thus unsurprising, because they serve as the cognitive bases for economic discourse and financial news. Table 2 presents the general information about the frequencies of the five dominant metaphors in CD and NYT.

As shown in Table 2, more metaphorical expressions are used in NYT (601) than in CD (471) in referring to the Renminbi. It demonstrates that compared with CD, NYT is more likely to discuss abstract areas of experience in terms of concrete areas of experience, so NYT might be more reader-friendly than CD. In both newspapers, the

Table 2: Frequencies of the five dominant metaphors in CD and NYT.

Type	CD		NYT	
	Freq.	%	Freq.	%
HEALTH	96	21	88	15
PHYSICAL MOVEMENT	158	35	287	49
MACHINE	72	14	92	16
PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR	93	21	62	9
VICTIM	52	9	72	12
Total	471	100	601	100

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PHYSICAL MOVEMENT metaphor makes up the largest share of all the metaphors used. It suggests that changes in the exchange rate are the primary focus of these news reports when referring to the Renminbi in the two newspapers. Charteris-Black (2004: 158) argues that "a main communicative goal of financial reporters is to discuss changing market values since these are highly newsworthy." The actual or potential changes in the value of the Renminbi thus have the greatest reader appeal and deserve the primary attention. Besides, the frequency of this metaphor is much higher in NYT than in CD. It indicates that NYT is more concerned about exchange rate changes than CD. The HEALTH/STRENGTH metaphor is used primarily to conceptualize the state of the Renminbi's value. The most frequently used word types in both newspapers are *weak* and *strong*, which are used respectively to conceptualize the low and high value of the Renminbi. However, the majority of them are used in their comparative forms (*stronger*/*weaker*) and verb forms (*weaken*/*strengthen*), so they are primarily used to describe exchange rate changes rather than the current state of the Renminbi, as in the following:

(6) (CD, 12/10/2010)
He indicated the *yuan* could become **stronger** over time if ...

(7) (CD, 28/10/2010)
A **weaker** *yuan* will prevent exports from further deteriorating, Li said.

The prevalence of PHYSICAL MOVEMENT and HEALTH/STRENGTH metaphors has also been identified in Charteris-Black and Musolff's (2003) study of euro trading in British and German financial press. Although the preference for the two metaphor themes can suggest the focuses of these news reports in the two newspapers, they are too conventionalized to serve important rhetorical and ideological functions in the two newspapers. However, the use of the other three metaphor themes – MACHINE, PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR, and VICTIM – is found significant to the construction of the rhetorical position and ideological stance of each newspaper. The following sections offer a close analysis of each of them.

5.1 Exchange rate policies are a machine

Previous studies on economic discourse and financial news have revealed that mechanical metaphors are very popular in contemporary economic discourse (Charteris-Black and Ennis 2001; White 2003; Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003; Charteris-Black 2004: Ch. 7; Fukuda 2009). White (2003) attributes this phenomenon to the dominant position of mechanical and industrial elements in Western

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culture as a result of the industrial revolution and the central position of mechanical processes in economic activities. Mechanical processes and their accompanying lexis have permeated economic discourse and become so conventionalized that they can provide "ready-made sources for metaphorical exploitation" (White 2003: 143).

Based on the MIP, a number of metaphorical expressions related to the source domain of a machine are found being used to conceptualize China's exchange rate policies, such as *mechanism*, *peg*, *adjust/adjustment*, *dent*, *convert*, *spark*, *fuel*, and *trigger*. The conceptualization of exchange rate policies as a machine entails not only how the machine works but also the necessity for maintenance. However, an examination of these metaphorical expressions finds that the two newspapers show distinct differences as regards to what extent and how the machine should be maintained. In CD, only the word type *adjust/adjustment* can be identified to describe how the exchange rate machine should be maintained. The keyword analysis also demonstrates that the tokens of *adjust/adjustment* are keywords in CD but not in NYT when the two corpora are compared with the BNC sampler corpus. The preference for *adjust/adjustment* suggests that CD prefers the minor improvement of the machine of China's exchange rate policies, as in the following:

(8) (CD, 03/08/2005)
Although the overall impact the slight **adjustment** of the *renminbi*'s exchange rate has on agriculture will be mild for the time being ...

In NYT, apart from a few occurrences of *adjust/adjustment*, there are several occurrences of another word type, *overhaul*, which carry the implicature that the machine is currently in a bad condition and is in need of thorough inspection and repair. The keyword analysis also confirms that it is a keyword in NYT but not in CD when the two corpora are compared with the BNC sampler corpus. It suggests NYT's differing view of the machine of China's exchange rate policies. Examples are as follows:

(9) (NYT, 22/06/2010)
China... announced last weekend that it would proceed with a long-awaited **overhaul** of its *currency* controls ...

The two newspapers' different views of China's exchange rate policies are also reflected in their conceptualizations of the working of China's exchange rate policies. Of all these word types, the most frequently used in both newspapers is *peg*. The token *peg* is a keyword in both CD and NYT when they are compared

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with the BNC sampler corpus, with a keyness value of 349.92 and 291.65, respectively. They are used to conceptualize the linking of the Renminbi's value to the dollar, as in the following:

(10) (CD, 28/06/2010)
Beijing's ending of the *yuan*'s **peg** from the dollar last week temporarily boosted share prices of airlines, paper manufacturers ...

CD features the exclusive use of the word type *peg* to describe the linking of the Renminbi's value to the dollar, because it carries no explicit evaluative meanings. However, apart from the neutral word type *peg*, alternative metaphorical expressions with explicit and implicit negative evaluative meanings can also be identified in NYT, such as *fix*, *tie*, *lock*, and *yoke*. They suggest that China's exchange rate policies are too rigid and need to be improved, as in the following:

(11) (NYT, 15/10/2009)
By keeping China's currency, the *renminbi*, tightly **yoked** to the weak and weakening dollar ...

(12) (NYT, 31/10/2003)
China has kept the value of the *yuan* **locked** at a fixed exchange rate to the dollar ...

5.2 The currency dispute is a physical conflict/war

The dominance of PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR metaphors in economic discourse has also been demonstrated and discussed in a number of studies (e.g., Eubanks 2000; Charteris-Black and Ennis 2001; Koller 2003; Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003). Koller (2003: 6) suggests that the source domain of the WAR metaphor is dominant in business media discourse because the metaphor is not uniform, varying from physical violence to military strategy. She attributes this phenomenon to the fact that war originates from basic physical fighting in the course of human history. In their study of the metaphorical construction of euro trading in English and German financial press, Charteris-Black and Musolff (2003: 146) found that English financial discourse features the frequent use of metaphorical expressions related to the source domains of boxing and of war, so they use the term PHYSICAL COMBAT to characterize this kind of aggressive behavior related to war and boxing. While acknowledging the wide range of source domains of PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR metaphors, these studies often discuss them together, overlooking the different functions they may serve in business discourse. The present

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analysis, however, shows that the choice between PHYSICAL CONFLICT and WAR metaphors in the two newspapers may carry significant rhetorical and ideological meanings in the representations of the currency dispute between China and the United States.

In both newspapers, a number of metaphorical expressions have been identified as belonging to the source domain of PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR, and typical word types include *impact*, *war*, *fight*, *regime*, *attack*, *tension*, etc. Examples are as follows:

(13) (CD, 05/10/2011)
... said they are concerned about the influence of the legislation, which might lead to a *currency* **war** and could sink the global economy.

(14) (NYT, 22/11/2010)
But even without the *currency* **fight**, the economics of sock-making here are shifting.

Their primary function is to conceptualize the nature of the currency dispute. As Table 2 shows, more metaphorical expressions of this type are used in CD (93) than in NYT (62). It suggests that CD is more likely to conceptualize the currency dispute as a conflict than NYT.

The metaphors of PHYSICAL CONFLICT and WAR are often discussed together because they share a great deal of similarity in conceptual schemata. Both involve two opposing parties who fight each other in a certain circumstance, for a certain purpose, and with certain consequences. Consequently, they are often instantiated by the same metaphorical expressions, such as *impact*, *damage*, *hurt*, *harm*, and *threaten*. They can be assigned to either the WAR or the PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphor, so it is sometimes very hard to make a clear distinction between them in analysis (Charteris-Black and Musolff 2003). However, there are still some metaphorical expressions which can be distinctively identified as solely WAR or PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors. Typical word types for WAR metaphors are *war*, *regime*, *front*, *survival*, and *rally*, while those for PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors are *fight*, *lash*, *pinch*, *squeeze*, and *hit*. One of their primary differences resides in the fierceness and scale of the conflict they depict. Therefore, these metaphorical expressions can be roughly classified into three groups: PHYSICAL CONFLICT, WAR, and both.

As Table 3 shows, CD is characterized by a high preference for WAR metaphors but a low preference for PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors. In contrast, NYT shows a more or less equal preference for both types of metaphors. These different preferences serve to construct their respective views of the fierceness of the conflict. NYT prefers to conceptualize the US government's action toward China as a physical

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Table 3: Classification of PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR metaphors.

Types	CD		NYT	
	Freq.	%	Freq.	%
PHYSICAL CONFLICT	17	18	23	37
WAR	44	47	26	42
Both	32	34	13	21
Total	93	100	62	100

conflict, realized by such metaphorical expressions as *fight*, *chide*, *lash*, *assail*, *wiggle*, *spat*, *wrangle*, and *at loggerheads with*, as in the following:

(15) (NYT, 17/11/2010)
Meanwhile, the American companies most likely to oppose Washington's currency **fight** with Beijing are businesses like PS Brands ...

Tokens of this type cannot be found in CD, which, instead, repeatedly conceptualizes the dispute and the United States' actions against China as a war. This can be witnessed in some frequently used word types, such as *war*, *regime*, *ammunition*, *defend*, *front*, and *rally*, as in the following:

(16) (CD, 25/01/2011)
That has provided some foreign nations, including the United States, with **ammunition** to pressure China to allow its *currency* to rise ...

(17) (CD, 06/07/2010)
Top brass at international hotel chains are closely watching developments on the *currency* **front**.

In (16) and (17), the tokens *ammunition* and *front*, whose basic meanings are related to war, are used in CD to conceptualize a certain aspect of the currency dispute, respectively: the excuse which can be used to press China and the development of the currency dispute. It suggests the influence of the underlying ideological schema THE CURRENCY DISPUTE IS A WAR.

Besides, CD is also noted for its special emphasis on the use of this type of metaphorical expression to dramatize the impact of the currency dispute, especially Renminbi appreciation. This can be perceived in CD's preferential use of the token *impact*, which is a keyword in CD (with a keyness value of 266.49) but not in NYT when the two corpora are compared with the BNC sampler corpus. While both newspapers feature the use of those metaphorical expressions which

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can be assigned to either PHYSICAL CONFLICT or WAR metaphors, such as *impact*, *damage*, and *hurt*, CD shows preference for WAR metaphors and some powerful PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors to dramatize the impact of the currency dispute, such as *war*, *cut*, *batter*, *survival*, and *blow*, as in the following:

(18) (CD, 25/10/2010)
The dispute between the US and emerging countries is seen to be a possible prelude to a global *currency* **war**.

In contrast, NYT prefers some PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors which imply the small impact of the currency dispute or the Renminbi appreciation, e.g., *squeeze* and *pinch*, as in the following:

(19) (NYT, 16/11/2010)
Big American multinational manufacturing companies can feel the **pinch** of dollar–*renminbi* fluctuations.

As examples (18) and (19) show, CD tends to conceptualize the impact of the currency dispute in a much fiercer way than NYT. These differences in conceptualizations and preferences are certainly not arbitrary, because they communicate different rhetorical effects. NYT's preference for PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors serves to downplay the fierceness of the conflict between China and the United States and the aggressiveness of the US government's action. The conceptualization of the dispute as a physical conflict activates a win-or-lose schema, so it justifies the United States' action, because the loss of a fight is a shame. However, CD tends to use WAR metaphors to dramatize the pressure from the United States, and this can easily evoke the collective memory of China's history of being colonized by Western countries. A WAR metaphor characterizes China as the victim and the United States as the aggressor. It activates a life-or-death schema, and turns the question of the Renminbi appreciation into a question of whether China can either resist the aggression from the United States or be annihilated. Through playing up nationalistic feelings, it entertains the dominant ideology of anti-Americanism that has been cultivated in Chinese media in the last two decades (Lee 2003). Therefore, it can help to legitimize China's rejection of the US government's request for any move in the currency issue.

5.3 The renminbi is a victim

There are also a cluster of expressions which serve to conceptualize the Renminbi as a victim. They can be viewed as emerging from the more general

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metaphor in economic discourse like THE ECONOMY IS A HUMAN (Charteris-Black 2000). However, the VICTIM metaphor is also instantiated in two different ways. The dominant way of instantiation is to conceptualize the Renminbi as a victim of government control or manipulation, i.e., a manipulated victim. This can be perceived through some frequently used metaphorical expressions, such as *manipulate/manipulator*, *free*, *intervene*, *liberalization/liberalize*, *tightly controlled*, *keep a tight rein*, and *loosen its grip*. In particular, the most frequently used word type *manipulate/manipulator* is a keyword in both CD and NYT when the two corpora are compared with the BNC sampler corpus. See the following example:

(20) (NYT, 16/04/2009)
President Obama repeatedly accused China of outright *currency* **manipulation** during the presidential campaign ...

The conceptualization of the Renminbi as a manipulated victim activates the schema of an authoritarian government who deprives its subjects of their freedom. It also suggests the working of underlying neoliberal ideologies, which privilege free-market logic, deregulation, and the minimal control by the government (Harvey 2005). From a neoliberal perspective, the manipulation of the exchange rate should be sanctioned and redressed. Consequently, the conceptualization of the yuan as a manipulated victim helps to conceptualize the request for Renminbi appreciation as a just move for fighting the freedom of the Renminbi and the United States as a liberator for the "manipulated" Renminbi. The ideology behind the use of this metaphor can also be revealed through other related metaphorical expressions like *liberalize* and *free*.

(21) (NYT, 12/10/2002)
... it would not amount to a significant Chinese move toward *currency* **liberalization** ...

Although the word type *manipulate/manipulator* can also be identified in CD, they are used mainly for intertextual reasons, and the majority of them are used in such a way that they are either explicitly negated or implicitly suggest that China is not manipulating its currency, as in the following:

(22) (CD, 22/05/2009)
Senate Banking Committee on Wednesday that China did not **manipulate** the exchange rate for export advantage ...

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However, an alternative way of conceptualizing the Renminbi as a victim can be identified in CD. It conceptualizes the Renminbi as a victim of wrongful accusations, depicting it as a scapegoat for the problems of other countries, especially the United States, as in the following:

(23) (CD, 16/10/2010)
Yuan a "**scapegoat**" for Washington's trade and unemployment woes.

This particular way of conceptualization, though with only much fewer occurrences, is found frequently intersected with the occurrences of other metaphors, like WAR and HEALTH/STRENGTH metaphors, as in the following:

(24) (CD, 19/10/2010)
The US is aiming at the wrong **target** by blaming the *yuan* for its economic woes, analysts said.

(25) (CD, 12/10/2010)
Officials and economists have said a **stronger** *yuan* is not a **panacea** for global imbalances ...

In (24), the scapegoat ideology is found underlying CD's conceptualization of the United States' blaming of the yuan as aiming at the wrong target with the WAR metaphor. In (25), it is realized in the conceptualization of the yuan as a medicine for the disease in global economy through the HEALTH/STRENGTH metaphor. The keyword analysis also confirms that the token *scapegoat* is a keyword in CD but not in NYT when they are compared with the BNC sampler corpus. This particular way of conceptualization is crucial to the construction of the rhetorical position and ideological stance of CD, because it highlights the US as the cause of the Renminbi's problems and China as the protector of the Renminbi. It helps to reject the United States' accusation of the Renminbi as the cause of the United States' economic problems and justify China's stance toward the issue.

6 Conclusions

The above analysis shows that while five dominant metaphors can be identified in both newspapers – PHYSICAL MOVEMENT, HEALTH/STRENGTH, PHYSICAL CONFLICT/WAR, VICTIM, and MACHINE – they are appropriated and reformulated in different ways to construct the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper. In particular, NYT prefers to depict the dispute as a physical conflict and

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the Renminbi as a victim of government control and manipulation, and argues for the overhaul of the machine of China's exchange rate policies. CD favors the conceptualization of the dispute as a war and the Renminbi as a scapegoat for the problems of the United States, and insists on the adjustment of the machine of China's exchange rate policies.

These different ways in metaphor use can be explained in terms of their roles in the construction of the argumentative position and ideological stance of each newspaper and the particular sociopolitical context. Despite its liberal stance and critical reporting style, NYT aligns itself with the dominant American interests in arguing for Renminbi appreciation. This can be witnessed in its particular preference for PHYSICAL MOVEMENT metaphors and the emphasis on the overhaul of the machine of China's exchange rate policies. Through conceptualizing the Renminbi as a victim of government control and manipulation, it depicts the United States as a fighter for the freedom of the Renminbi. While justifying the US government's action toward China in the dispute, it also deliberately downplays the fierceness and impact of the conflict through the preferential choice of PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors. This can be understood in terms of the intricate political and economic relationships between the United States and China in the currency dispute. Despite its continuous requests for Renminbi appreciation, the US government also tries to avoid a direct confrontation with China on the issue in view of the risks of a large-scale trade war. In contrast, CD, as a typical party organ, aligns itself with the Chinese government's interests by insisting on the adjustment of the machine of China's exchange rate policies. It rejects the United States' accusation of China as a currency manipulator by arguing that the Renminbi is a scapegoat for the problems of other countries, especially the United States. Unlike NYT, it deliberately dramatizes the fierceness and impact of the conflict by showing a particular preference for WAR rather than PHYSICAL CONFLICT metaphors as a warning of the risks of the currency dispute as well as the potentially huge impact of Renminbi appreciation on China and its trade partners.

Therefore, this article demonstrates that what is of particular concern to the study of the representations of the same issue by different newspapers is, more often than not, not the choice of different metaphor themes but the incorporation, appropriation, and manipulation of the same or similar metaphor themes to advance their varied or even competing political and economic interests (Flowerdew and Leong 2007; Burnes 2011; Chiang and Duann 2007). This suggests the importance of a contextualized study and the relevance of detailed information about the sociopolitical contexts (López and Llopis 2010). However, since this study only compares the metaphorical construction of the currency dispute by looking at the concordance citations of three interrelated key terms, it

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can be predicted that there must be some other important metaphors employed in these news reports but remaining submerged in the present study. Further studies will be conducted to examine the presence and functioning of other metaphors through other means.

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Bionote

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